



High on Hospitality

JAIPUR It's a classic case of boomerang. Jaswant Singh, BJP leader and former external affairs minister, landed in a soup for allegedly offering an opium-mixed brew at a social function in his village Jassol last week, while hosting Chief Minister Vasundhara Raje's dissidents.

On November 5, special judge (Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances Act) Bhawani Shankar Kumawat ordered the police to

register a case against him and 10 other BJP leaders, all Raje's dissidents. Under the Act, they face up to 10 years of imprisonment.

The case was lodged on the insistence of Jodhpur resident Om Prakash Bishnoi through his lawyer Malam Singh Chowdhary. Separate complaints have also been lodged with Narcotics Control Bureau, Jodhpur, and Central Bureau of Narcotics, Kotaboth, asking the Government to

SNUFFED: Singh offering opium to a partyman probe the procurement of opium distributed at the event. Singh denies offering opium and insists it was kesar (saffron). Locals say opium-mixed brew is offered as a welcome drink in most social functions in desert villages of the state. In a custom known as "manuhar", opium is offered under various names, including kesar.

The BJP leader and the co-accused have been caught on camera offering the brew. However, what may come to his rescue is the fact that there may not be enough eye-witnesses to vouch for the accusation.

But it is turning out to be a big political embarrassment for Singh who is already under Raje's scanner for supporting her dissidents. They have been targeting Raje on her liquor policy and questioning the ethics and morality of her ministers. The BJP top brass is mum on the issue as Raje and company are one up on the rebels this time. **by Rohit Parihar**

SIGNPOSTS

KILLED: Jharkhand BJP executive committee member **Ganga Prasad Jaiswal**, by six armed men who allegedly kidnapped and murdered him in Sirsairusu.

WON: By Delhi's **Yuki Bhambri**, 15, the Asia Oceania ITF junior tournament. He beat China's Wu Di 6-3, 6-1.



ARRESTED: **Som Deb** alias Ajit Phukan, 'second lieutenant' in ULFA's elite 28 battalion, and his wife **Khanikar** in Assam.

DIED: **Swami Gahanananda**, 91, 14th president of the Ramakrishna Math and Mission, of which he was the general secretary from 1989 to 1992.

DIED: Veteran journalist **K. A. Azeez**, 70. He was the former editor and publisher of the now defunct Malayalam eveningers *Cochin Express* and *Indian News*.

VIS-A-VIS **J. JAYALALITHAA** AIADMK supremo **versus** **M. KARUNANIDHI** Tamil Nadu chief minister

“
Karunanidhi had secret ties with LTE and had been helping them. He has no right to be the chief minister.
”



SAURABH SINGH

“
LTE political chief S.P. Thamilselvan was a Tamil. As Tamil blood flows in me, I expressed my condolence.
”

EPILOGUE: If blood be the criteria, many more allegiances will have to be kept.